

M-ZRT (ELI5)

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Research Note

The system evaluates automatically

Internal **evaluation** can be defined as the rapid emergence of thoughts such as: “Am I doing this right?” and “What’s the point?”.

Move your shoulders for a few seconds, then observe what happens. Very quickly, an evaluation appears: “Am I doing this right?” “What’s the point?”. It often arises even before the action itself, in the form of **anticipation**.

Now repeat exactly the same movement, but while facing a first-person shooter (FPS) video game, with HUD off. This time, evaluation does not activate immediately. It seems delayed by a few seconds, often around 4 to 5 seconds.

Without a game:

Anticipation ~5 seconds

Shoulder movement ~3 seconds

+1 second: emergence of meaning-search and evaluation (“Am I doing this right?”, “What’s the point?”)

This process is **automatic**. It reflects a **monitoring system** that activates in a nearly inevitable way. Trying to block it voluntarily tends to reinforce it, because the attempt itself becomes an object of evaluation.

With an FPS, HUD off:

Anticipation ~2 seconds

Shoulder movement ~3 seconds

+5 seconds: emergence of meaning-search and evaluation

What we observe here is a temporal shift. Evaluation is not removed, but delayed. This delay creates a window during which the action can exist without being immediately captured by the monitoring system.

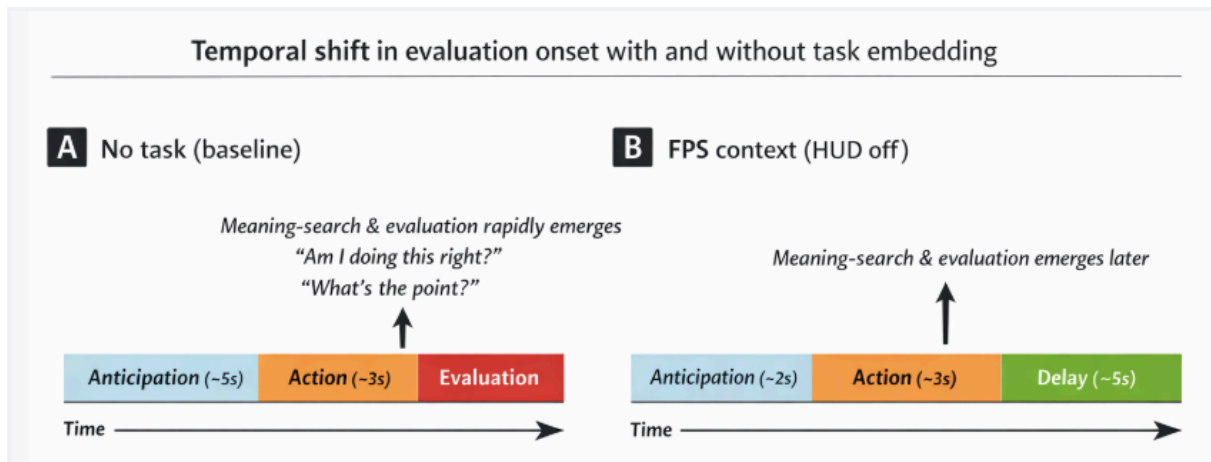


Figure 1: Evaluation is not removed, it is delayed. Task context creates a brief window where action escapes immediate monitoring.

This therefore becomes a first useful exercise to make visible the mechanism we are trying to bypass. Compare with and without the game, and consider this contrast as a first “attack” on the internal monitoring system, as if it were momentarily stunned.

This result shows that **there is a temporal window** during which evaluation is delayed. During this interval, the action is not immediately captured by processes of meaning, optimization, and judgment.

In other words, it becomes possible to introduce micro-events that are not immediately evaluated. These are not “messages” in an explicit sense, but rather action configurations that temporarily escape the filtering of the monitoring system.

The goal is to push it back enough to create a stable window. When this shift is strong enough, one can observe the reappearance of more intense dopaminergic responses.

The monitoring system does not only evaluate actions. It also monitors attempts to bypass it. It therefore includes the “setups” themselves, such as choosing a game.

This is why the first hours of a game are often experienced as “magical,” and then the effect fades. The system learns the context, anticipates what will happen, and reintegrates the experience into an evaluative loop.

This leads to an important constraint:

Yes, it is possible to introduce micro-events that temporarily **escape evaluation**, but these events must remain very brief and non-repetitive.

As soon as there is anticipation, comparison, or an attempt at reproduction, the monitoring system reactivates and captures the event. Forcing or repeating only reinforces this capture.

After a too explicit or repeated attempt, the system remains active and vigilant for some time, making subsequent attempts much less effective.

From a practical standpoint:

the duration must remain very short (up to ~1 minute at most)

the event should not be repeated multiple times within the same day

it should be left without analysis or attempts at reproduction

it should be treated as a one-off event, then abandoned

In other words, this is not a cumulative or optimizable practice. It operates as a **switch-like** logic, and should not become something to improve.

Familiarity Closes the Window

Suppose I give you a task to perform. The first time, you discover it. Anticipation is relatively low, because the action is not yet well known.

But afterward, you know what to expect. Anticipation increases. The monitor recognizes the situation, reactivates, and **captures** the action. At that point, the task loses its effect, because it is immediately evaluated.

If you wait longer, for example a day, part of that familiarity fades. The memory is less precise, anticipation decreases. The context becomes partially “open” again.

Under these conditions, the monitor is less active, or slower to trigger. The task can pass again.

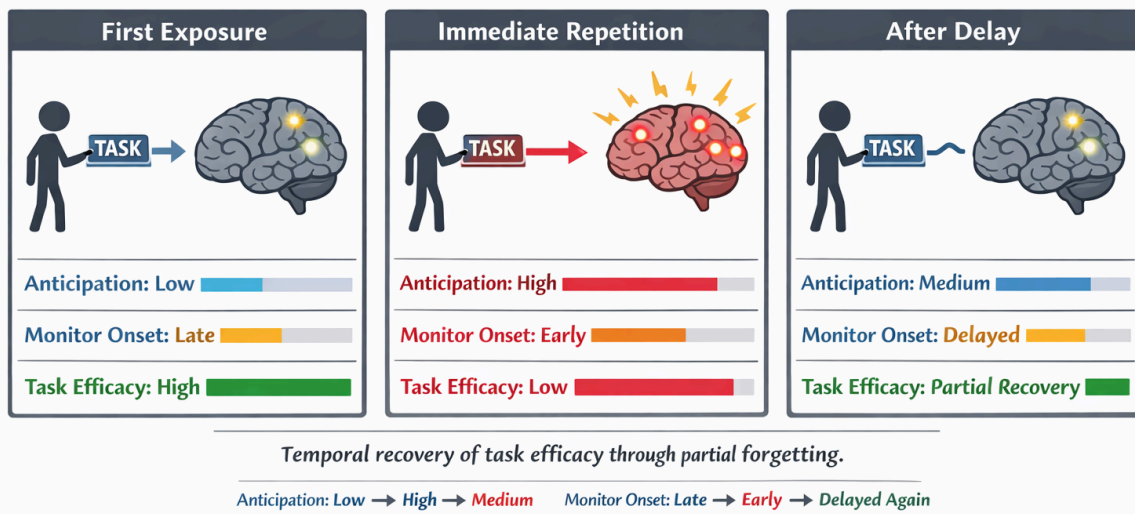


Figure 2. Temporal recovery of task efficacy through partial forgetting. On first exposure, low anticipation allows the action to unfold before evaluative monitoring engages. With immediate repetition, anticipation increases and the monitoring system activates earlier, rapidly capturing the task. After a delay, partial decay of the representation reduces anticipation, slowing monitor onset and reopening a brief window in which the task can again operate. However, this does not mean the task works better on the first attempt, as multiple attempts may be required.

What kind of signals?

We can introduce a more technical idea here: prediction error.

A fast-paced game, such as an FPS, constantly generates micro-violations of prediction, which temporarily disrupts the operation of the monitoring system.

If, within this window, you perform a simple gesture, only once, without trying to evaluate it, that gesture becomes a particular kind of signal, indicating: optimization does not apply here.

We can then distinguish two types of signals entering at the same time:

prediction errors (coming from the game, from the unpredictable flow)

a local suspension of optimization (the gesture performed without evaluation)

It is their combination that destabilizes the monitoring system.

Paradoxically, the monitor does not oppose the task directly, it even tries to improve it. It evaluates, corrects, adjusts, in close interaction with the optimization system. The two operate almost as a single unit.

This is why thoughts such as:

“What is the best exercise?”

“How can I do it better?”

appear almost automatically.

But these thoughts are already forms of evaluation. So they reactivate precisely the system we were trying to disengage.

The key point is the following:

the monitor can cooperate with the attempt, in order to better turn it into an object of optimization.

And once the task becomes an object of optimization, it is neutralized.

We can therefore consider that:

The monitor and the optimization system are not separate. They form a single functional unit.

This unit has a very specific property:

it suppresses or reshapes anything that cannot be integrated into action or optimization

As a result, non-instrumental intensity cannot be maintained and is either suppressed or reformatted into goal-directed signals.

The task:

Download Unreal Tournament (1999), remove the HUD, and start a match with no performance goal. Do not try to win.

While playing:

make a brief shoulder movement, only once, without prolonging it

then, let your attention float lightly over the game, without fully engaging

take a very small sip of coffee

Then:

close the game

do not analyze anything

completely forget the exercise

On subsequent days, you can perform the task again, but occasionally vary the sequence, for example by taking coffee before the game. The goal is to keep the pattern from becoming recognizable. In the same spirit, you can also skip a day at random to maintain unpredictability.

The coffee is there to slightly stimulate. The dose should remain low, to avoid making the state too “suspicious” for the monitoring system.

Important point, to make very clear:

This is not a routine to optimize.

If you start asking yourself:

“What is the best order?”

“What is the best dose?”

“How can I improve the effect?”

then you have already reactivated the monitor.

Reference:

Morin, F. (2026). *The Morin Z-Reduction Task (M-ZRT): Suspension of Instrumental Framing as a Threshold Mechanism for Ease*. Preprint. Canonical version: <https://florianmorin.com/morin-non-use-task.html>.

